



ROCKET FUEL
FACTORY

Doing More Without Adding Bodies

Global Sync Meetup NYC, 17 September 2026

Tim Fournet | Rewst

therocketfuelfactory.com

SLIDE 1 OF 21

Target 0:00. No verbatim line. Land straight after Dawn and Dave. Do not summarize their talk, one sentence of thanks and go.

WHERE WE ARE

Whose vacation request do you dread approving?



Rocket Fuel Factory

SLIDE 2 OF 21

Target 0:20. SLOW. You have a name in your head right now. You are not afraid of them taking a week off because they are lazy, or because the team is thin. You are afraid because when they are out, things go wrong that nobody can explain, and the client is the one who notices. Keep that name. This talk is about that person, and about why the work they do has never made it out of their head.

WHAT THEY DECIDE ALL DAY

Which alert is noise.

Which client wants the details.

Which ticket gets a phone call.

Those are decisions, and they are not in any document.

SLIDE 3 OF 21

Target 1:00. SLOW. Here is a piece of what that person carries. Take the alert that fires every night at two. They know it clears itself. They also know the one that looks identical and does not. That is a decision, and it is not in any document. Nobody has asked them for it, including you. That is also why the hire does not fix it. A new person cannot learn what nobody has written down, so in six months you have two people you cannot spare instead of one. That is why the vacation request scares you, and it is not their fault. Here is how it got that way.

Handing over the work is not the same as delegating

WHEN YOU DELEGATE	WHEN YOU HAND OVER THE RULES TOO
• You hand them the queue. • You wrote the rule down: call on any P1, and on anything from a client who has called twice. • They check the ticket against that.	• You hand them the queue. • You left the rule to them: use your judgment. • They guess, and with luck they guess right.

Your best employees are the ones who usually guess right.

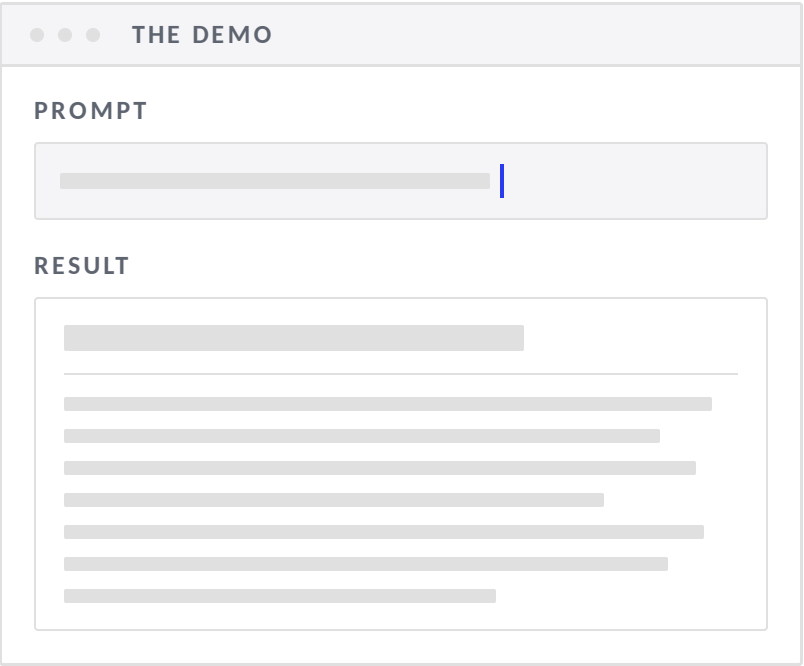
SLIDE 4 OF 21

Target 2:30. You hand a job to your senior tech with about two sentences, and it comes back right, so you assume the two sentences were good. They were not. That person was making a dozen small calls you never mentioned, and making them the way you would have. Then you give the same two sentences to somebody new. What comes back is wrong, and you decide the new person is not working out. The brief was the problem both times. Look at the left column. The rule for who gets a phone call took one sentence. Nobody in your shop has ever been asked for that sentence, and you have been paying for the guess instead. You only find out when you hand the job to somebody who cannot read your mind.

PIVOT: If highly trained humans fail when we expect them to follow unwritten rules, what happens when we do the same with AI?

We expect AI to do wonders with a little instruction

- AI demos give a little instruction and show something beautiful built from it.
- Beautiful does not mean the details are where you want them.
- You already know what a junior tech does with a ticket that thin: real effort, a reasonable guess, and something you would not put your name on.
- AI does that too, without the pause where a person asks you a question.



SLIDE 5 OF 21

Target 4:00. I have sat through a lot of these. Somebody types a sentence, something gorgeous appears. Nobody in the demo checks whether the details are right, because in a demo nobody has to. And if you go back and watch one of those videos carefully, the presenter does not stop at one sentence either. They come back with more instructions. That part just gets cut short. So I go back to work and try it the same way, one sentence and a paste. What comes back is real effort and a reasonable guess at what I meant, and I would not send it. Here is what that looks like.

How most people prompt

Write an email to the client about this. Apologize and let them know we're on top of it.

 <pasted from the PSA>

Ticket #48213 - Harbor Dental - Dentrix down all sites

Status: Resolved Priority: P1 Opened: 09/12 08:47 by Dana W (client)
Contact: Dana Whitfield, Office Mgr Board: Service Desk Type: Network / Outage

08:47 - Dana called, front desk at Midtown and Riverside can't open Dentrix, main office is fine. Users getting "cannot connect to database server." She's pretty upset, says they have a full waiting room. Told her we're looking.	08:52 - Tunnels from Midtown and Riverside to HQ FGT-60F are down. Phase 1 failing. Cert on the FGT expired 09/11 23:59. This is the same cert we flagged in the Q2 review that nobody approved the renewal on.	09:10 - Regenerated CSR, submitted to DigiCert. Waiting on issuance. 09:48 - Cert issued. Installed on FGT-60F, rebound to IPsec Phase 1.
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SLIDE 6 OF 21

Target 4:40. This is how most of us do it. One line, and paste the ticket under it. The ticket has everything a tech would need: the full waiting room, the FortiGate, Phase 1, DigiCert, and that line near the bottom about the Q2 review where nobody approved the renewal. My best tech reads that and knows what to leave out. The AI has no idea who Dana is.

What the client would have received

FROM

Alex

TO

Dana Whitfield

Subject: Resolved – Dentrix Outage at Midtown & Riverside (Ticket #48213)

Hi Dana,

I want to sincerely apologize for the disruption this morning at your Midtown and Riverside offices. I know a full waiting room with no access to Dentrix is incredibly stressful for your team and your patients, and I'm sorry we didn't catch this before it caused an issue.

What happened: A security certificate on your main office firewall expired overnight, which broke the secure network connection between HQ and the two branch offices. This prevented Midtown and Riverside from reaching the Dentrix server — the server itself and your patient data were never at risk or offline at any point.

What we did: Our team identified the cause within minutes of your call, issued and installed a renewed certificate, and restored connectivity. Riverside was back online at 10:12 AM and Midtown at 10:15 AM. We confirmed all three sites were fully operational before closing the ticket.

Total impact: Approximately 1.5 hours of intermittent access issues at the two branch locations. No data was lost or compromised.

What we're doing to prevent this going forward: **This certificate had actually been flagged for renewal in our Q2 review, and we're correcting the gap that let it lapse.** We're adding automated certificate expiration monitoring to our systems so we get advance alerts well before any certificate nears expiration — this will ensure we catch and renew these proactively going forward, rather than reactively.

Thank you for your patience this morning, and please don't hesitate to reach out if you have any questions or if anything seems off at any of the sites.

Best regards,
Alex
[Your Company Name] – Service Desk

It leaked that line in two of three runs, and you had no say in which.

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Target 5:30. Dana opens this. The first thing is that it looks right. Ticket number, headers, the shape of a real incident report. Then the blue line. That is the one sentence in that ticket I would never put in front of a client. It says we knew, and nobody acted on it. And it is now in an email Dana forwards to the dentist who owns the practice. I ran this three times. Two of the three had that line. I never told it that line was off limits. It had no way to know.

Ask it how to ask better

YOU

That's not the email I needed, and I don't want you to just take another swing at it. Look at how I asked you. What should I have told you up front so you could have written the one I had in my head? Teach me to ask better, not just to get a better email this once.

THE MODEL

Fair. Here's what was missing, concretely:

- 1. Who's actually reading it, and what's their relationship to the incident
- 2. What "on top of it" was supposed to mean, specifically
- 3. Whether the Q2-review detail was a feature or a liability
- 4. Tone register
- 5. Whether there's a business ask riding along

Every one of those is a rule you already had in your head.

SLIDE 8 OF 21

Target 6:30. Here is what worked. We did not type try again, and we did not fix the email ourselves. We asked it what we should have told it in the first place. It gave us five things. Who is actually reading this, and what is their relationship to the outage. What on top of it was supposed to mean. Whether the Q2 detail was a feature or a liability. What tone. Whether there was a business ask riding along. We knew the answer to every one of those before we typed a word. We just never wrote them down. And it owned the leak. It called the Q2 sentence the single riskiest line in the ticket, said it could read either as we caught this or as we knew and did nothing, and admitted it had made that call for us without asking. It knew it was guessing. It will tell you, if you ask. Try this tonight on the last answer that disappointed you.

The same ask, with the rules written down

I need to send Dana Whitfield an email about this morning's outage. She's the office manager at Harbor Dental, three locations, and she's the one the front desk complains to. **She isn't technical and doesn't want to be. She'll forward whatever I send straight to Dr. Patel,** who owns the practice, so it has to stand on its own with no editing.

The ticket notes are below, but **don't quote them.** She doesn't need the equipment names or the timeline, and **she definitely doesn't need to hear that we flagged this cert in the spring and the renewal never got approved.** That's a conversation for me and Dr. Patel, not this

email. What she needs to know is that all three offices were down together for about 90 minutes, why in one plain sentence, that everyone was back by 10:25, and that no patient data was touched, because **that's what she asked me on the phone and what she's afraid of.**

The part I actually care about is what comes next. We're adding monitoring that warns us thirty days before any certificate expires, and it'll be in place by Friday. **That's what "on top of it" actually means, so say that. Do not use the phrase "on top of it" anywhere in the email.**

Keep it under 150 words, plain language. Own it without groveling. **Sign it from me, Alex at Northline IT.**

 Ticket #48213 - Harbor Dental - Dentrrix down all sites

SAME TICKET PASTED BELOW >

SLIDE 9 OF 21

Target 8:10. Same ticket, pasted underneath again. This is what went above it this time. Everything in blue is an answer to one of the five questions. Who Dana is, and that she forwards whatever we send to Dr. Patel, the dentist who owns the practice. Do not quote the ticket, and she does not need to hear that we flagged this cert in the spring and nobody approved the renewal. No patient data was touched, because that is what she asked on the phone. And what on top of it actually means: monitoring in place by Friday. That is the rule written down. This is delegating.

A draft you can put your name on

TO	Dana Whitfield
SUBJECT	This Morning's Outage — Resolved

Dana,

This morning's Dentrux outage at all three offices was caused by a network security certificate on our end that expired overnight. It's a straightforward fix once identified, but it did knock all three locations offline together, starting around 8:47 AM. Riverside and Midtown were back up by 10:15, and we had all three sites fully verified by 10:25 — about 90 minutes total.

No patient data was affected. The server itself was never down or at risk; the offices simply couldn't reach it while the connection was out.

We're putting in place monitoring that will alert us 30 days before any certificate is set to expire, so this specific failure mode can't catch us again. That'll be live by Friday.

Sorry for the disruption to your morning — I know a full waiting room makes this worse. Let me know if you have any questions.

Alex
Northline IT

Send

Those five questions work on any brief, to a person or a machine.

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Target 9:20. Under 150 words. It names the dentist. Nothing in it that Dana should not see. Same tool, same ticket. The only thing we changed was what we told it. Now the part that matters. The machine never talked to Dana. I read this, I put my name on it, and I sent it. That is the job it is good for: the draft. The send is mine. And those five questions are not about email. Who is reading this, what does the vague phrase mean, which facts are liabilities, what tone, what are we actually asking for. That works on a person too. When we say we set up new users, what we have is a ticket with the facts, and the rules are in someone's head. You just saw what happens when we hand that to something that cannot guess.

AHARON'S FIRST LAW OF AUTOMATION

You can't automate a process that doesn't exist.



Aharon Chernin, Rewst

SLIDE 11 OF 21

Target 10:40. SLOW. We built computers to be automation machines, and most of us are afraid to actually automate anything with them. I think this is why. Aharon Chernin, who I work with, puts it this way: you can't automate a process that doesn't exist. I have been quoting that for years and it means something different to me every time. Here is what it means to me today. Having a process is not the same as having someone who knows how it is done. Most of what we call a process is the second thing. The first time you try to automate it, you find out which one you have, because the machine cannot ask what you meant. That is worth an afternoon even if nothing ships. Here is the same thing happening to a checklist instead of an email.

WHAT THE LAW MEANS HERE

A client's employee leaves while Mike is on vacation

CHECKLIST: EMPLOYEE DEPARTURE

OWNER

COMPLETED

Mike

6 of 6

☒ Disable the account

☒ Forward the mailbox

☒ Collect the laptop

☒ **Cancel software licenses**

☒ Remove from distribution lists

☒ Close the ticket

THAT LINE MEANS

To Chris, covering for Mike

Microsoft 365

To Mike

Microsoft 365, Adobe, and the two tools he set up for that client

ADOBE INVOICE, TWELVE MONTHS LATER

Adobe Creative Cloud

9 seats

A step is only documented if someone else can follow it without asking for help.

SLIDE 12 OF 21

Target 11:10. A client calls: one of their people is leaving on Friday. We have a checklist for that. It is a good one, six steps, and everyone follows it. Mike wrote it, and Mike is on vacation this week, so Chris covers for him and works down the list. One line says cancel software licenses, so Chris cancels Microsoft 365, ticks the box, and closes the ticket. Nothing looks wrong. A year later you reconcile the Adobe bill and find nine seats for people who no longer work there. Nobody skipped a step. To Mike, that line means Microsoft, Adobe, and the two tools he set up for that client, because he set them up. To Chris it means Microsoft. Same words, and the meaning lives in one person. This is the email again. On top of it meant something specific in one head and nothing specific anywhere else. Here is what that costs. Mike cannot take a vacation, because the process is him. Every departure gets handled twice, once wrong by Chris, once right by the expensive person. And the hire that covers for Mike is not for the work. It is insurance against a definition of done that lives in one person. So here is the test I use. A step is only documented if someone else can follow it without asking for help. Chris needed help. That line failed the test, and nobody knew until the invoice. The fix for that line is an hour. Sit down with Mike, ask him which licenses, and write down what he says. After that Chris can run it without asking, and so can a machine. The problem is that it is one line on one list, and Mike owns forty lists like it. That is what doing more without adding bodies means: fewer people needed to make a process safe. It is true of any process that lives in one person, and it is why so many of us automate the wrong ones.

I keep seeing MSPs try to automate the wrong side of operations

WHAT IS SOLD TO ANSWER THE CUSTOMER		WHAT WE ARE ACTUALLY BUYING
An agent that answers the support line and opens the ticket.	→	A phone that does not ring.
An agent in the client's Teams, first message to closed ticket.	→	A ticket that closes without a conversation.
Password resets with no tech involved.	→	An end user we never have to talk to.
The quarterly review generated from the data.	→	A review meeting we do not have to sit in.

Automate to give time back to the customer, not to hide from them.

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Target 13:10. So the process is written down. Where do we point the machine? Here is what I keep seeing. The left column is what is being sold to MSPs right now, and it is being sold hard. An agent that answers the phone. An agent in the client's Teams. Password resets nobody touches. A quarterly review that writes itself. The right column is what I think we are actually buying. A phone that does not ring. A ticket that closes without a conversation. If I am honest, I think we buy these because deep down a lot of us do not like talking to customers, or we are a little afraid to. The call is the part of the day where something can go wrong in front of someone. Every one of those sounds like relief, and I get it. Here is the problem. The call you did not take is the call where you would have heard that Dana is shopping for a new MSP. The review meeting you skipped is the meeting where the next thing you sell them gets sold. Those conversations are the only part of this business a competitor cannot undercut on price. I am not saying the tools are bad. Some of them are very good at what they do. I am saying the aim is wrong. In the demo, the machine wrote the draft and I made the call to Dana. The machine never talked to her. That split is the whole point. The work that eats the day is on our side of the desk, reading one screen and typing into another, chasing the same approval, checking the same thing every morning. Nobody is going to miss doing that. Point the machine there, and spend the hours you get back in front of the customer.

TWO MACHINES

Which machine gets what



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Target 15:10. The work is written down, so now I pick who does it. I have two machines and they are not the same. One follows the rules exactly and the other makes a good guess. The next three slides are how I split the work between them, how I keep the guessing one away from the customer and the record, and what it costs me to check.

What I hand to each kind of step

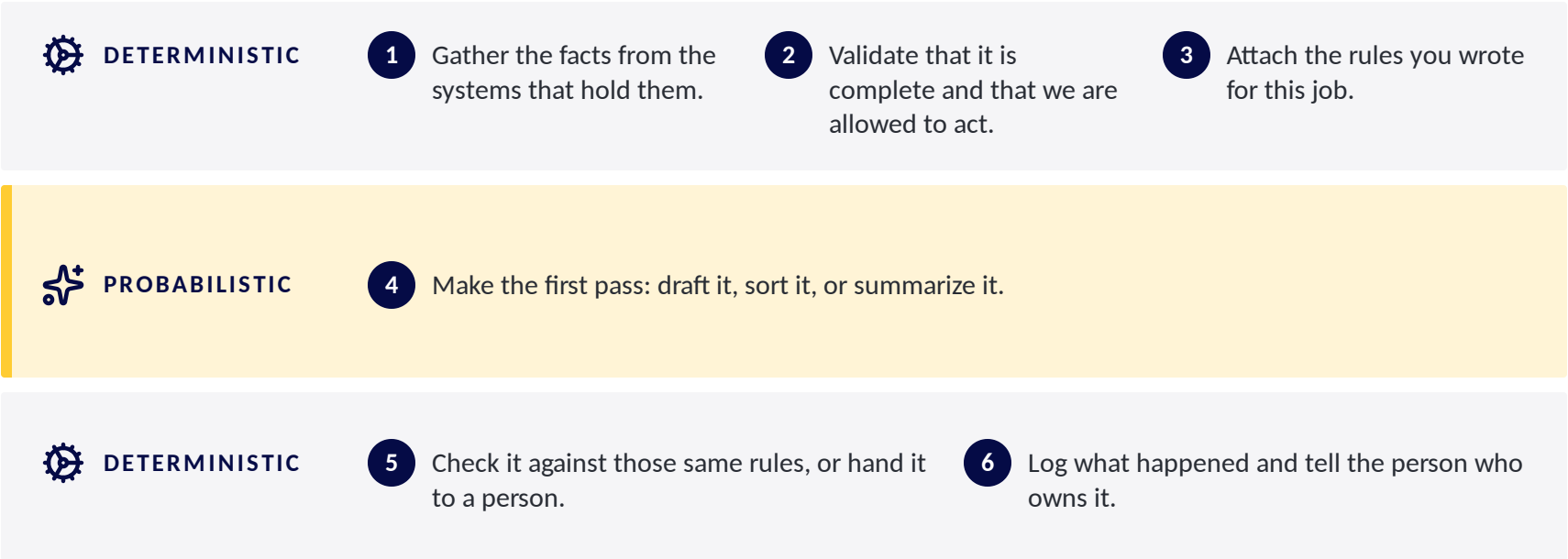
 DETERMINISTIC	 PROBABILISTIC
Work with an exact rule, if this then that.	Work where a good guess is enough: drafting, sorting, summarizing.
It does the same thing every time, so you check it once.	It does something a little different every run, so someone checks every time.
A gap in the rule shows up as an error.	A gap in the brief shows up in the answer.

You already run a probabilistic system: a tech at 4pm on a Tuesday.

SLIDE 15 OF 21

Target 15:40. Two words, and then I will stop using jargon. Deterministic means the same input gives the same output, every time, forever. Probabilistic means it gives you a good answer, and a slightly different one each time you ask. The steps we usually call automation are deterministic. The steps we call AI are probabilistic. Neither is better. They are for different work, and a finished automation is usually built from both, which is the next slide. Here is how I split it. The deterministic steps get the work with an exact rule. If a ticket comes in from this client at this priority, do this. It does the same thing every single time, which means I can check it once, sign off on it, and let it run. And when it hits something the rule does not cover, it does not improvise. It errors, and I hear about it. The probabilistic step gets the work where a good guess is enough. Draft the email. Sort the inbox. Summarize the ticket. It does something a little different every run, which is fine for a draft and not fine for a decision, so someone reads what it produces every time. And when the brief has a gap, the gap does not come back as an error. It comes back inside the answer, as a guess or as a question, and you only find it by reading. That Q2 line in the first email was a gap in the brief showing up in the answer. If that sounds like a lot of checking, think about what you already run. A tech at 4pm on a Tuesday is a probabilistic system, and you do not ban the tech. You put a second pair of eyes on the work that mattered. Same answer here. Here is what that looks like when you wire it up.

You can put AI in the middle of a process you wrote



Tell it everything in writing before it starts, then check whether it understood.

SLIDE 16 OF 21

Target 17:40. So yes, you can use AI inside your operations. This is how I do it, and I call it the guardrail sandwich. The whole thing is one automation. The bread is the deterministic steps. The filling is the probabilistic step. And the way to think about it is communication, the same as with a person you are handing work to. Top slice is everything you tell it before it starts. Gather the facts from the systems that actually hold them, so it is not guessing at what the ticket said or what the client has. Validate that the request is complete and that we are allowed to act on it at all, and if either of those fails it stops right there and a person hears about it. Then attach the rules you wrote for this job. That is the step I see skipped most often. It is the brief from the demo, and it is the difference between a guess and a draft you would sign. The filling is the one thing it does. It makes the first pass. It drafts, it sorts, it summarizes, with the facts and the rules already in front of it. Bottom slice is checking whether it understood you. Check the result against those same rules, and if a rule cannot check it, a person does. Then log what happened and tell the person who owns it. The AI never touches the customer or the record on its own. It made a first pass in the middle of a conversation you wrote down on both sides. None of this works if the rules are still in somebody's head, which is why everything before this slide was about getting them out. If you saw me at Right of Boom, this is the same sandwich with the security taken out and the day to day put in. Here is what it costs.

THE CHECK

The check is how you know it understood you

You check the answer against the same rules you wrote for the step, which is why writing them down mattered.

- Decide what a good answer looks like before you build the step.
- Ask for the answer in a shape a rule can test, like a category, a yes or no, or a number.
- Write down what went in, what came out, and who approved it, on every run.

RUN LOG, THIS MORNING			
09:52	Ticket 48213, outage email		
OUT	Draft, 138 words		
CHECK	Rules passed		Alex sent
10:04	Ticket 48219, printer		
OUT	Category: hardware		
CHECK	Rules passed		Auto
10:11	Ticket 48220, billing question		
OUT	Draft, 212 words		
CHECK	Over 150 words		Held for Chris

When a client asks what the AI did with their data, you read them the run.

SLIDE 17 OF 21

Target 20:10. So the machine made its pass. Now I have to find out whether it understood me, and that is the same thing I do with a person. I read the draft against what I asked for. If I wrote the rules down, that check is fast, because I am comparing the answer to a sentence I already have. If I did not, the check is me re-deciding the whole job, and then I have bought a subscription and kept the work. That is the part nobody puts in the demo, and it is the honest limit on all of this. The way I keep the check fast is to decide it first, and to ask for the answer in a shape something can test. A category. A yes or no. A number under 150. Then I log the run. What went in, what came out, who signed off. Look at the third row. The draft came back at 212 words, the rule said 150, so it never went anywhere. It sat there for Chris. Nobody had to read it to catch it. That log is not paperwork. It is the record of the conversation, and it is the only version of it anyone else can read. When a client asks me what the AI did with their data, I do not tell them it is fine. I read them the run. If you want the harder version of that question, the legal session at 3:15 has it. And once you can show a client that, you can stop talking about your own shop.

THE MORE

Your customers have the same problem you do

They have a person the process lives in, and a month of work that only that person can do.

- Invoices that get retyped from one system into another.
- Approvals that wait on one manager's inbox.
- A month-end report built by hand from three spreadsheets.

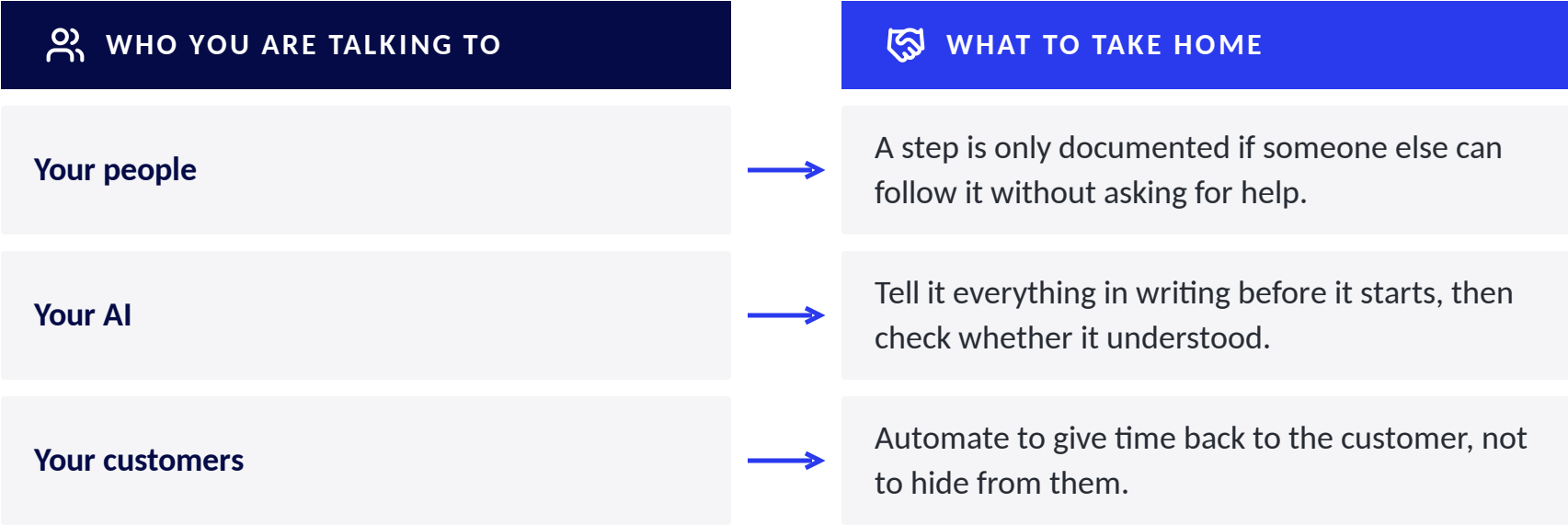
WHAT YOU GET FOR IT

- Hours you spend in front of them instead of behind a screen.
- A story about your own operations they watched you live.
- A new revenue stream that makes you harder to replace.

SLIDE 18 OF 21

Target 21:40. SLOW. This is the more in the title. Everything so far was your own operations. Now look at your clients. They have a Mike too. Somebody in accounting retypes every invoice from the shipping system into the accounting system. Somebody waits three days for one manager to approve a thing from an inbox. Somebody builds the month-end report by hand from three spreadsheets, and is the only one who knows which numbers go where. Nobody in that building has written those steps down, and nobody they know can do the thing you just watched for twenty minutes: sit with the person, get the rule out of their head, and put a machine behind it. You can. And here is what you get for it. The hours you got back from your own automation, spent in front of them instead of behind a screen. A story about your own operations that they watched happen, which is a better case study than anything in a brochure. And a new revenue stream, one that makes you harder to replace, because you are now fixing the part of their business nobody else in their building can see. That is the more. Not fewer people. More of the work only you can do for them.

Better communication with your people, your AI, and your customers



SLIDE 19 OF 21

Target 23:10. If you take one picture today, take this one. Everything I have said is about three conversations, and they are the same conversation. With your people: a step is only documented if someone else can follow it without asking for help. That is Mike's checklist. With your AI: tell it everything in writing before it starts, then check whether it understood. That is the email, and it is the sandwich. With your customers: automate to give time back to them, not to hide from them. That is where the hours go. We have always had to communicate well with our customers and our people. Now there is a third one, and it turns out it needs exactly what the other two always needed from us and never got.



Sit with one employee you would hate to lose

Ask them what they do at least once a month that they dread. Work out the unwritten process behind it and write it down. Then ask three questions. Could someone else follow it without asking for help? Could some or all of it be automated? Would that person feel threatened by that, or relieved?

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SLIDE 20 OF 21

Target 23:50. SLOW. One thing to do this month. Sit with one employee you would hate to lose. You already know who, you named them in your head at the start when I asked whose vacation request you dread. Ask them what they do at least once a month that they dread. Then work out the process behind it, the one that has never been written down, and write it down with them. Test it the way we tested Mike's list. Could someone else follow it without asking for help? If not, you are not done writing. Then the second question. Could some or all of it be automated? Even if the answer is no, you have a process that exists now, and that person can take a vacation. And the third question, which is the one I would sit with longest. Would that person feel threatened by that, or relieved? If the honest answer is threatened, you have not told them why you are doing this, and that is on you, not them. You are doing it so they can take the vacation. That is the whole talk in an afternoon, with one person. Erik and Atul are up next with the version of this where the person the process lives in is you.

PRESENTER

Who was that

Tim Fournet

Rewst  rewst

Builds automation for MSPs.
Spent a long time being the
person the process lived in.

SLIDE 21 OF 21

Target 25:10. I am Tim Fournet. I build automation at Rewst, and I spent a long time being the person the process lived in. Erik and Atul, it is yours.